AI EXPLAINED SIMPLY

Your Free Brain Stack: Step-by-Step Guide

Replace one hour of scrolling with one hour of learning, using free AI tools and one document you already own.

Before you start

- Pick ONE source: a lecture PDF, a work report or a long article (a public page saved as PDF works too).
- Put your phone in another room for the hour.
- Tool names change. Google renamed NotebookLM to Gemini Notebook in July 2026, so you may see either name. Free usage limits also change: check the usage page in the app.

The hour (60 minutes)

| Minutes | Step | Tool |

|---|---|---|

| 5 | Read the study guide | NotebookLM / Gemini Notebook, Studio, Report |

| 15 | Take the quiz without looking | Studio, Quiz |

| 10 | Read the mind map, find the empty branches | Studio, Mind map |

| 10 | Ask a chatbot for a 20-minute plan | Gemini or ChatGPT (free) |

| 20 | Retry the questions you missed | Same quiz |

Step by step

1. **Upload one source.** NotebookLM accepts PDFs, websites, Google Docs and YouTube transcripts. Answers come from your files, with pointers to the page they came from.

2. **Study guide.** In Studio, make a Report and choose Study guide (the help page also lists Briefing document and FAQ).
3. **Quiz.** In Studio, generate a Quiz. Answer in your head first, then check. A wrong answer is the thing to learn.
4. **Mind map.** Generate it, then note which branches you keep missing.
5. **Plan.** Paste the weak spots into a free chatbot with the prompt below.
6. **Flashcards.** Only for questions you got wrong twice.

Prompts to copy

- `I have 20 minutes a day. Here are the 3 topics I missed in my quiz: [paste]. Give me a plan for tomorrow with one small task per topic.`
- `Explain [topic] to a 10-year-old using only the text of my document, then ask me one question about it.`
- `Turn the topics I got wrong into 5 short flashcards (question on one side, answer on the other).`
- `Here is my plan: [paste]. Cut it down to what fits in 20 minutes.`

The 30-day plan

- Week 1: one source, one full run. Learn the loop.
- Week 2: add flashcards for terms you keep forgetting.
- Week 3: switch to a new source so the habit does not depend on one topic.
- Week 4: retake the quiz on your first document and compare your score.

What can go wrong

- Free limits change and sources online disagree. Check the usage page in the app and come back later if you hit a limit.
- A quiz can contain a bad question. If an answer looks wrong, check the page it points to: your document wins.
- A chatbot plan is a draft. You decide; cut anything too big.

Tip

Say each answer out loud in your own words. If you cannot say it simply, you have not learned it yet.

Sources

- Google Help, NotebookLM / Gemini Notebook, Studio outputs: https://support.google.com/notebooklm/answer/16206563
- Wikipedia, NotebookLM: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/NotebookLM

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